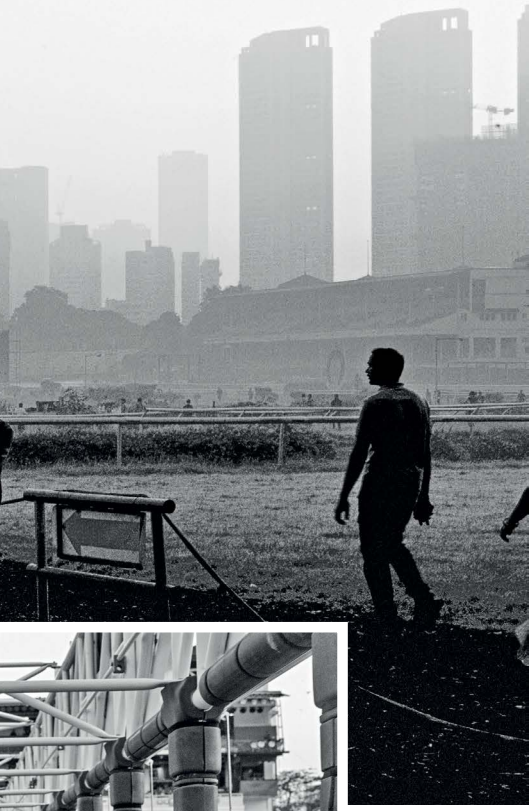


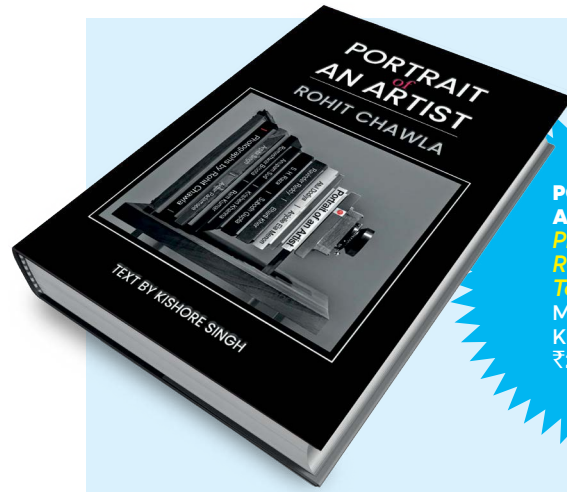


QUIET GALLOPS Mahalaxmi Racecourse; (inset) Jockeys at the starting gate, 2016

stumbles upon horses in their element, wild and free. Scenes that are even more relevant at a time when the racecourse is set to lose a certain character to development.

"The joy of photography for me is a lack of intentionality, having absolutely no idea what I'm doing. Until I heard of redevelopment plans on the anvil. That's when the intentionality came in. I wanted to create something that was enduring," he says. A part of what *RACEDAY* holds is legacy that will be snatched from its rightful owners. Those who make it tick backstage, those whose hearts beat in sync on race day. And walkers-turned-lurkers like Sippy. ■

—Shail Desai



PORTRAIT OF AN ARTIST
Photographs by Rohit Chawla
Text by Kishore Singh
MAPIN PUBLISHING/ KNMA
₹2,500; 280 pages

BOOKS ▼

MASTERS IN MONOCHROME

ROHIT CHAWLA provides a rare window into the private world of Indian artists through his striking portraits

Rohit Chawla joined JWT, the advertising titan, in the late 1980s—a decade and half after I had left its India version: HTA (Hindustan Thompson Associates). In this interim, everything had changed: the spray-painting of black-and-white photographs, the surgical precision of cut-and-paste typefaces from foreign magazines and the stark layouts that lacked the freedom of visual expression. Rohit was to become the mirror of that change. He used the mobility of his body and graphic ad-brain to invent original frames. He gave us new eyes like the images of Ashvin Gatha and Raghubir Singh had once done from abroad.

WE ENTER THE GREEN ROOMS OF 68 ARTISTS WHO APPEAR WITHOUT MAKE-UP, IN FULL VIEW, IN A WAVE OF STARK CINEMATIC IMAGES

It can't be an easy choice to pick one of Rohit's genres as a favourite, because he has excelled in several: the anthropological Rebari show; the re-imagining of the essence of Ravi Varma, Klimt and Kahlo's art; the surreal fashion frames of his Wearable Art; the social activism of *The Quiet Portrait* and *Untangling the Politics of Hair*; the smoke of Havana cigars and the pathos of *Rain Dogs*.

This little magic-box-of-a-book, mastered by the text of Kishore Singh, uses his own art journey to enter the green rooms of 68 artists who remain without make-up even as they appear in full view like a new wave of stark, cutting-edge cinematic images. Kishore writes about art and artists with conversational ease, not even trying to impress himself! He is aware that today, good jargon can sell bad art, while good art doesn't need marketing explanations in any other language. Thanks to the duo, the portraits and their tales will enter posterity alongside their canvases. ■

—Aman Nath